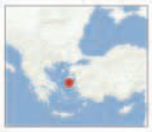
ROME ACHIEVES MASTERY OF THE MEDITERRANEAN

AFTER THE DEFEAT OF CARTHAGE, Rome turned its attention to the eastern Mediterranean, where regional powers were engaged in their own struggles for dominance. Macedonia and Seleucid Syria possessed imposing fleets, while the island of Rhodes was a major naval power. The mauling of the Macedonian fleet at Chios in 201 BCE opened the way for Roman involvement in the region as an ally of Rhodes. Macedonia and the Seleucids were defeated and Egypt occupied, leaving the Romans with no one to fight at sea except pirates—and one another.

The civil wars in the second half of the 1st century BCE, as Rome made the transition from republic to empire, brought major sea battles that had a crucial impact on the outcome of the struggle for power. The defeat of Sextus Pompeius at Naulochus left Octavian and Mark Antony the only contenders for leadership of the Roman world. The issue between them was settled at Actium in 31 BCE. With Octavian installed as the Emperor Augustus, Roman naval mastery of the Mediterranean was established. It remained virtually unchallenged for the next two centuries.

SECOND MACEDONIAN WAR

CHIOS



Date 210 BCE
Forces Macedonians: 53 large ships, c.150 others; Rhodians and allies: 65 large ships, 12 others
Losses Macedonians: 42 ships; Rhodians and allies: 9 ships

Location Off Chios, Aegean Sea

Philip V of Macedon was fighting for control of the eastern Mediterranean. Rhodes and Pergamon formed an alliance against him, aided by Cyzicus and Byzantium. Philip had landed an army on the island of Chios when he was surprised by a fleet under the Rhodian admiral Theophiliscus and the Pergamonese ruler Attalus.

Some of the ships engaged in the ensuing battle were huge polyremes with eight or ten oarsmen to each column of oars. One of these monsters, the Macedonian flagship, was sunk early in the battle when its ram stuck inextricably in a smaller vessel, exposing it to ramming from both sides. The small, nimble Rhodian galleys attacked from the flank, ramming Philip's ships from the rear or slicing off their oars. But the Macedonians made good use of smaller galleys to protect their larger ships from ramming and held off their attackers with catapults mounted on the high decks.

Both allied commanders were in the thick of the contest. Theophiliscus was wounded three times coming to the aid of one of his quinqueremes that was sinking surrounded by enemy ships—he later died of his injuries. Attalus was forced to run his flagship ashore to escape enemy pursuit. Philip escaped with the majority of his ships, but his losses had been extremely heavy.

ROMAN–SELEUCID WAR

MYONESSUS



Date 190 BCE
Forces Romans and Rhodians: 83 ships; Seleucids: 90 ships
Losses Romans and Rhodians: 3 ships; Seleucids: 29 ships

Location Off west coast of Turkey

Between 192 and 188 Rome, in alliance with Rhodes and Pergamon, fought a war against the Seleucid ruler Antiochus III of Syria. The Seleucid admiral Polyxenidas, based at Ephesus, came out to give battle to a combined Roman and Rhodian fleet off Myonnesus. Control of the Aegean was at stake. The Rhodians under Eudoras skilfully maneuvered their lighter, faster galleys, blocking an attempted outflanking move by Polyxenidas by swiftly transferring from one wing to the other. They broke up the Seleucid formation through the aggressive use of incendiary devices. The heavier Roman ships under Lucius Aemilius Regillus punched through the center of the enemy line. In places, with opposing ships locked together, crews and marines fought hand-to-hand. Once the Seleucids realized that there were Roman ships to their rear, they turned and fled. This victory gave Rome command of the sea, enabling its armies to carry the war to a successful conclusion on land.

PIRACY IN THE MEDITERRANEAN

POMPEY'S CAMPAIGN AGAINST THE PIRATES



Date 67 BCE
Forces Pompey: 500 ships; Pirates: unknown
Losses Pompey: unknown; Pirates: 846 ships surrendered

Location Mediterranean

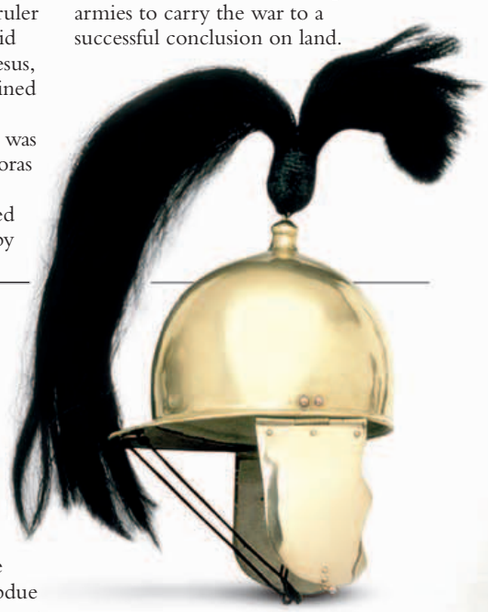
Despite Rome's nominal sovereignty over the Mediterranean Sea, the seafaring inhabitants of ports and coastal areas were inevitably tempted to make a living preying on merchant vessels, especially during the frequent periods when Rome was preoccupied with civil wars. The unpoliced waters became too hazardous for trade, while the pirates grew ever richer and bolder, raiding Rome's port of Ostia and kidnapping Roman officials on the Italian coast.

After several ineffectual attempts to crack down on piracy, in 67 BCE the politician and general Pompey, known as "the Great," was given wide-ranging powers and large-scale resources for a war on the pirates. He divided the Mediterranean into 13 zones, each under a legate with army and naval forces at his command. Pompey himself kept a roving brief, leading 60 ships in pursuit of the most troublesome and persistent offenders.

In a mere 40 days during the spring Pompey swept the western Mediterranean clear of pirates, most submitting virtually without a fight. He then turned to the eastern Mediterranean, the heartland of piracy. On Crete and along the coast of Cilicia in Asia Minor pirate chiefs held many ports and strongholds. Pompey went after them in person, taking with him a large quantity of siege equipment in the expectation of hard fighting to subdue fortified pirate bases. But as in the west, a show of strength usually sufficed. According to Roman historian Florus, at the approach of Pompey's galleys the pirate crews would throw down their weapons, relinquish their oars, and clap their hands as a gesture of surrender.



Coin of Pompey the Great
Issued by Pompey's son Sextus Pompeius, this silver coin shows Pompey's head with a trident in honor of his achievement of ridding the Mediterranean of pirates.



Legionary helmet
The sight of Pompey's well-equipped legions was enough to make most pirates surrender. This replica helmet is of a kind widely used in the 1st century BCE.

Pompey is reported to have taken just 71 pirate ships in combat, out of 846 captured in the campaign. Pirates were resettled where the Romans could keep an eye on them and there was more chance of making an honest living.

> "THERE WERE OF THESE CORSAIRS ABOVE A THOUSAND SAIL, AND THEY HAD TAKEN NO LESS THAN 400 CITIES ..."
>
> **PLUTARCH**, GREEK HISTORIAN OF THE 1ST CENTURY CE IN HIS *LIFE OF POMPEY*